Yet, this Modi statement flew in the face of assertions in recent political science research on India that claimed a significant resurgence of upper-caste dominance between 2009 and 2019 within the BJP. Most recently, the Paris-based Sciences Po's Christophe Jaffrelot, declared that the 2019 poll marked 'the revenge of the upper-caste elite,' aligned with the 'BJP against the Dalits' and OBCs' assertiveness'.[3] Jaffrelot and Ashoka University's Gilles Vernier argued that the decade of 2009–2019 saw an erosion of OBC representation in the Hindi belt. As they put it, 'the last decade has seen *the return of the savarn (upper caste) … and the erosion of OBC representation …* along with the rise of the BJP. The trend started in 2009, but the Modi wave of 2014 has confirmed it and the last [2019] elections have resulted in a certain consolidation of this come back to the pre-Mandal scenario [emphasis added].'[4] Specifically, they have claimed that within the Hindi belt, upper castes accounted for a whopping 44.9 per cent of the BJP MPs in the Lok Sabha, OBCs only for 19.7 per cent and SCs for 18.5 per cent.[5] In Parliament, overall, they claimed that BJP dominance was driven by 36.3 per cent upper-caste MPs within the party and only 18.8 per cent OBCs (the lowest OBC representation in a major party, compared to the Congress and the regional parties) in a recent academic caste profile of the 2019 Lok Sabha. 'Upper caste representation among BJP MPs is significantly higher' than its rival parties, they argued. They further emphasised that this 'over-representation of upper-castes largely stem from the Hindi-belt states dominated by the BJP.'[6]

It is impossible to square these two claims. Modi claimed a preponderance of lower classes in BJP's elected representatives. Jaffrelot and Vernier, using a database on the social backgrounds of elected legislators co-produced by Ashoka University's Trivedi Centre for Political Data,[7] claimed a growing upper-caste stranglehold on the BJP in the Modi–Shah years. One is right. The other is clearly wrong. I found this to be a strange conundrum. It is usually easy for neighbours, relatives and local journalists to establish the caste one belongs to. It is unusual for there to be uncertainty on such matters. Caste is an easily demonstratable fact.